Happenings in Handmade

A CCI initiative

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A BODY BLOW TO THE HANDMADE CARPET INDUSTRY

Can the artisans and the art survive it?



In the one month of July-August 2025, the US announced two startling, back-to-back tariffs of 25% each, for specified handmade exports from India.

Notable among these are the country’s world-famous carpets. The US accounts for over 60% of India’s carpet exports. Out of the ₹13,000 crores of carpets shipped worldwide in the current year, more than ₹8,000 crores were to the US.



Fine Indian woollen carpets serve US markets well.

The figures reflect the enormity of this contemplated move. If implemented, it will have a devastating impact on the more than 30 lakh lives in this labour-intensive industry.









It includes not only skilled artisans, men and women, but also sheep farmers, wool, silk and cotton yarn suppliers, expert dyers and a rural network of warehouse owners, transporters and exporters.

They are spread across our northern regions, mostly in Kashmir, Rajasthan, U P and Punjab and Haryana, living and working with the precious knowledge of ancient Persian weaving conventions.



Sheep farming is a crucial livelihood for small and landless Kashmiri farmers. They produce 70 kg of wool annually. Now what?

The threatened tariff imposition has sent shockwaves among all the stakeholders. It’s choking their cash flows and forcing the weavers to stall production, in order to reduce losses before they become too much to bear.



Languishing stockpiles will strike at the heart of the community

This move will drive the community (already struggling to compete with cheaper mass-produced carpets) to the brink of unemployment and starvation. This in turn will have a ripple effect on vast village economies and societies.



Carpet weaving has been part of skills training in many jails across north India for over a century. Now this is also threatened.



A steep price hike could also push U.S. buyers toward cheaper, machine-made options, leaving Indian artisans in the lurch.

We, the members of the Crafts Council of India can help by spreading the word in our circle of architects, home decor designers, prospective home buyers and well-wishers of Indian crafts to purchase only Indian handknotted carpets for their requirements; sooner than later, in fact rightaway.

We don’t want to be doomsday prophets but chances are very real that if the U.S.tariffs are not reversed, or at least reduced considerably, they will destroy the Indian handmade carpet industry and with it, snuff out a noble, treasured 500 year old craft from our country. Never to be revived.

Credits

The Economic Times

The New Indian Express

MAP Academy, Bengaluru